

Nervous System Regulating Cheat Sheet

Quick techniques to calm panic in the moment, and build a steadier baseline over time — by Oxana

Note: This guide is a self-help tool, not a substitute for professional medical or mental health care. If you're in crisis, please contact a licensed professional or emergency services in your area.

In Panic Right Now

■ Physiological Sigh

The fastest reset there is — about 10 seconds.

1. Two quick inhales through your nose (one big, one small on top)
2. One long, slow exhale through your mouth
3. Repeat 2–3 times

■ Box Breathing

Slows your heart rate and signals safety to your brain.

1. Inhale for 4 counts
2. Hold for 4 counts
3. Exhale for 4 counts
4. Hold for 4 counts
5. Repeat 3 cycles

■ 5-4-3-2-1 Grounding

Interrupts the panic spiral by anchoring you in the present.

1. Name 5 things you can SEE
2. 4 things you can TOUCH
3. 3 things you can HEAR
4. 2 things you can SMELL
5. 1 thing you can TASTE

■ Valsalva Maneuver

What doctors use to slow a racing heart in seconds.

1. Pinch your nose shut, close your mouth
2. Try to exhale forcefully without releasing any air
3. Hold that pressure 10–15 seconds, then release
4. Repeat 2–3 times

■ Cold Water Dive Reflex

Triggers a hard-wired reflex that drops your heart rate fast.

1. Fill a bowl with cold water (add ice if you have it)
2. Take a breath and hold it
3. Submerge your face 15–30 seconds, or splash repeatedly
4. Repeat 2–3 times

Daily Practice (build resilience)

■ Humming

The vibration stimulates your vagus nerve directly.

1. Put your fingers gently in your ears
2. Hum on the exhale for 30 seconds
3. Continue for 1–2 minutes

■ Progressive Muscle Relaxation

Releases tension your body's been holding without you noticing.

1. Tense one muscle group hard for 5 seconds (feet, legs, stomach, hands, arms, face)
2. Release and notice the difference
3. Move through each group, head to toe

■ Wall Pushing

Gives fight-or-flight energy somewhere to go.

1. Push both palms against a wall, shoulder height, for 10 seconds
2. Release, shake your arms out
3. Repeat 3–5 times

■ Shaking

Lets your body discharge survival energy, the way animals do naturally.

1. Start shaking your hands loosely
2. Let it spread up your arms, then your whole body
3. Continue 1–2 minutes, then slow to stillness

■ Yawning & Sighing

Stretches the vagus nerve and releases jaw and face tension.

1. Open your mouth wide, force an exaggerated yawn
2. Follow with one big, audible sigh
3. Repeat 3–5 times

■ Mindful Walking

Completes the motor pattern your body primed during panic.

1. Walk slower than your normal pace
2. Focus on each foot touching the ground
3. Notice your surroundings, not your thoughts
4. Continue at least 5 minutes

■ Self-Holding

Creates a felt sense of being held and contained.

1. Hug yourself — one hand under the opposite arm, other hand on your upper arm
2. Hold firmly, breathe slowly
3. Stay 2–3 minutes

■ Smell Anchor

Bypasses thinking and speaks directly to your brain's safety center.

1. Find something familiar and pleasant to smell (coffee, citrus, lavender)
2. Take 3–4 slow, deep inhales
3. Notice any feeling of safety that comes with it

■ Slow Orienting

Gives your nervous system a safety signal: scan for threat, find none.

1. Soften your gaze, let it go wide instead of fixed
2. Slowly scan the room, silently naming what you see
3. Let your eyes rest on anything pleasant to look at

Want guided, step-by-step support through any of these — right when you need it?

Message my Telegram bot anytime: t.me/YOUR_BOT_USERNAME

It walks you through each technique in real time, one step at a time.